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Rodney Duffett,
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*CORRESPONDENCE
Syed Khusro Chishty
✉ s.chishty@seu.edu.sa

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Influencer marketing and purchase intention among Millennials and Generation Z in Saudi Arabia: the mediating role of brand trust

Asra Inkesar¹, Shahid Alam¹, Asif Hasan¹,
Suliman Abdullah Alazzaz¹, Nusrat Khan², Farrukh Rafiq Ahmad²
and Syed Khusro Chishty^{2*}

¹College of Administrative and Financial Sciences, Saudi Electronic University, Riyadh, Saudi Arabia,
²College of Administrative and Financial Sciences, Saudi Electronic University, Jeddah, Saudi Arabia

Introduction: The proliferation of social media influencers has fundamentally reshaped consumer–brand interactions, particularly among younger generations in digitally active markets. Grounded in Source Credibility Theory and relationship marketing literature, this study investigates how influencer credibility, content authenticity, and influencer expertise shape brand trust and purchase intention among Millennial and Generation Z consumers in Saudi Arabia.

Methods: Data were collected via a structured questionnaire administered to 300 active social media users aged 18–45 years across Instagram, Snapchat, and TikTok. CB-SEM was used for analysis.

Results: Influencer expertise is the strongest antecedent of brand trust; content authenticity exerts a positive but modest effect. Brand trust mediates influencer attributes to purchase intention.

Discussion: The study extends theory to Saudi Arabia's generational and cultural context. The findings carry implications for sustainable marketing practice, as trust-centred influencer strategies can orient younger consumers toward more informed, values-driven consumption choices, contributing to SDG 12's agenda of responsible consumption and production.

KEYWORDS

brand trust, content authenticity, Generation Z, influencer credibility, influencer expertise, influencer marketing, Millennials, purchase intention

1 Introduction

In recent years, the influence of social media on digital platforms has radically reshaped consumer–brand interactions across the world. Digital media has shifted marketing communication from firm-controlled messages to interactive, socially embedded exchanges where consumers actively participate in content creation and dissemination (Mangold and Faulds, 2009; Kaplan and Haenlein, 2010). One of the most prominent outcomes of this shift is influencer marketing, which involves individuals with substantial social media followings endorsing or recommending brands and products to their audiences (Freberg et al., 2011; De Veirman et al., 2017). Influencer marketing has emerged as a powerful tool for firms seeking to engage younger, digitally connected consumers, particularly Millennials and Generation Z, who

increasingly rely on peer-generated content rather than traditional advertising (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017).

Beyond commercial outcomes, influencer marketing carries significant implications for sustainable consumption behavior. Millennials and Generation Z are increasingly identified as sustainability-conscious consumer cohorts whose purchase decisions are shaped by perceived brand values, authenticity, and social responsibility (Carrete et al., 2012; Hwang and Zhang, 2018). When influencers authentically communicate brand values—including environmental responsibility and ethical production—they function as credible sustainability advocates, capable of nudging younger audiences toward more deliberate and values-aligned consumption (Peattie, 2010; Reinikainen et al., 2020). In digitally active markets such as Saudi Arabia, where Vision 2030 explicitly targets sustainable economic and social development, understanding how influencer-generated trust shapes consumption intentions is therefore not merely a commercial question but a sustainability policy concern.

This transformation is especially evident in Middle Eastern markets such as Saudi Arabia, where social media penetration, smartphone adoption, and digital infrastructure have expanded rapidly over the past decade (Alalwan et al., 2017; Statista, 2023). Social media platforms such as Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok, and YouTube have become central channels for information, entertainment, and online commerce in the Kingdom. Consequently, digital influencers now play a critical role in shaping brand perceptions and purchase decisions, particularly among young Saudi consumers who are highly active on social networking sites (Al-Gasawneh and Al-Adamat, 2020).

Saudi Arabia's demographic profile—characterized by a large proportion of youth and young adults—creates particularly fertile ground for influencer marketing strategies. Millennials and Gen Z consumers are known to value authenticity, social interaction, and experiential consumption, making them more receptive to influencer-generated content than to conventional advertising formats (Priporas et al., 2017; Lou and Yuan, 2019). As brands increasingly pivot toward influencer-based marketing, understanding how influencer characteristics affect consumer behavior becomes essential. In this context, purchase intention may no longer be driven solely by traditional determinants such as price or functional attributes, but rather by social influence mechanisms, perceived credibility, trust, and emotional connections fostered by influencers (Ohanian, 1990; Erdogan, 1999).

Despite the rapid growth of influencer marketing globally and within the Gulf region, academic research focusing specifically on Saudi Millennials and Gen Z remains limited. Prior studies generally report a positive relationship between influencer credibility and consumer purchase intention, often mediated by constructs such as brand trust, brand engagement, or brand attitude (Hwang and Zhang, 2018; Lou and Kim, 2019). However, much of the existing empirical evidence originates from Western or East Asian contexts, limiting its generalizability to Saudi Arabia. The Kingdom's unique socio-cultural, religious, and digital environment may shape consumer–influencer relationships differently, underscoring the need for context-specific investigation (Alalwan et al., 2017; Abed, 2020).

In particular, there is a need to empirically examine how specific influencer attributes—including credibility, authenticity, expertise, and—operate among Saudi young consumers. Theory suggests that repeated exposure to influencers can foster perceived intimacy and trust, which in turn influences attitudes and behavioral intentions (Horton and Wohl, 1956; Sokolova and Kefi, 2020). These dynamics may manifest differently across generational cohorts due to variations in media usage patterns, values, and expectations.

Accordingly, this study focuses on three theoretically grounded influencer attributes—credibility, content authenticity, and perceived expertise—as antecedents of brand trust and purchase intention. The proposed structural model is empirically tested among Saudi Millennials and Generation Z, contributing a contextually grounded, generationally sensitive understanding of influencer marketing effectiveness in an emerging digital economy. This study makes four distinct theoretical contributions: (1) First CB-SEM study of this integrated influencer marketing model in Saudi Arabia; (2) Source Credibility Theory extended by disaggregating credibility into three empirically distinct dimensions; (3) One of the first empirically validated Millennial vs. Gen Z structural comparisons in a Gulf market with measurement invariance testing; (4) Novel integration of sustainable consumer behavior theory with SDG 12 and SDG 17 alignment in an influencer marketing model.

2 Literature review

2.1 Theoretical foundations of influencer marketing

Influencer marketing has emerged as a dominant strategy in contemporary digital marketing, fundamentally transforming how brands engage with consumers in online environments. Social media influencers (SMIs) are increasingly conceptualized as “human brands” whose personal credibility, relatability, and content creation capabilities enable them to influence consumer perceptions, attitudes, and behavioral intentions (Thomson, 2006; Khamis et al., 2017). Unlike traditional celebrities, influencers cultivate ongoing, interactive relationships with their followers, which enhances message persuasiveness and perceived authenticity (Abidin, 2016; De Veirman et al., 2017).

A central theoretical foundation for understanding influencer effectiveness is Source Credibility Theory, which posits that the persuasive impact of a communication depends on the perceived expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness of the message source (Hovland et al., 1953; Ohanian, 1990). When applied to influencer marketing, this framework suggests that influencer credibility—manifested through honesty, reliability, and transparency—along with perceived expertise in specific product categories, significantly shapes consumer attitudes toward endorsed brands (Erdogan, 1999; Lou and Yuan, 2019). Additionally, authenticity, defined as the perception that influencer content is genuine, sincere, and aligned with personal values, has emerged as a critical determinant of influencer effectiveness in digital contexts (Audrezet et al., 2020; Schouten et al., 2020).

Beyond informational cues, influencer marketing operates through affective and relational mechanisms that deepen consumer–brand connections. One such mechanism is, which refers to the illusion of a real, personal relationship that followers develop with media personalities through repeated exposure (Horton and Wohl, 1956). In social media environments, enhances emotional closeness, trust, and identification with influencers, thereby increasing receptiveness to brand messages (Labrecque, 2014; Sokolova and Kefi, 2020). Furthermore, emotional engagement and perceived content quality—such as creativity, informativeness, and entertainment value—contribute to higher levels of brand engagement and positive brand-related outcomes (Tafesse and Wien, 2018; Cheung et al., 2021).

Empirical research provides substantial support for these theoretical mechanisms. Prior studies consistently demonstrate that influencer marketing positively influences consumer purchase intention, often through mediating variables such as trust, brand engagement, attitude toward the brand, and perceived content quality (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017; Lou and Kim, 2019). These findings suggest that influencer effectiveness extends beyond direct persuasion, operating through relational and psychological pathways that foster long-term consumer–brand relationships.

2.2 Conceptual model

The proposed conceptual model examines how influencer-related factors influence consumers' purchase intention both directly and indirectly through brand trust. Influencer Credibility, Content Authenticity, and Influencer Expertise are positioned as key antecedents, reflecting the informational and relational value conveyed by social media influencers. These attributes are expected to enhance Brand Trust, which represents consumers' confidence and belief in the brand promoted by influencers (Figure 1).

Brand Trust, in turn, is hypothesized to positively influence Purchase Intention, consistent with relationship marketing and trust-based consumer behavior theories. In addition to the mediated paths, the model also proposes direct effects from IC, CA, and IE to Purchase Intention, acknowledging that influencer attributes may independently drive buying decisions without complete reliance on trust formation.

2.3 Influencer marketing and purchase intention: role of trust, engagement and mediating variables

Multiple empirical studies have confirmed a positive link between influencer marketing and purchase intention. This research draws insights from Source Credibility Theory (Hovland et al., 1953), the theory posits that a communicator's expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness significantly influence how persuasive a message is and how positively the audience responds to the endorsed brand. In the context of influencer marketing, this model has been extended to digital influencers, where perceived credibility directly enhances consumer attitudes toward the brand and reduces skepticism about the message. Several empirical studies directly support the positive relationship between influencer credibility and brand trust: According to the Source Credibility Theory and empirical influencer marketing

research, higher influencer credibility—characterized by expertise, trustworthiness, and authenticity—positively influences consumers' trust in brands endorsed by those influencers. Multiple studies demonstrate that credible influencer endorsements strengthen brand trust, as credibility reduces consumer skepticism, and enhances the perceived reliability of branded messages." Therefore this hypothesis was framed given as under:

H1: Influencer credibility has a positive effect on brand trust.

Within the framework of confirmatory structural equation modelling (SEM), content authenticity is conceptualized as a theoretically grounded latent construct reflecting the extent to which influencer-generated content is perceived as genuine, transparent, and aligned with the influencer's true beliefs and lived experiences. Authenticity has been widely acknowledged as a critical antecedent of trust formation in relational exchanges (Morgan and Hunt, 1994). In influencer marketing contexts, authenticity functions as a signal that mitigates consumers' skepticism toward persuasive intent and enhances perceived integrity of brand-related communication (Friestad and Wright, 1994; Audrezet et al., 2020).

Drawing on Signaling Theory, authentic content reduces information asymmetry by conveying credible cues regarding both the influencer's motives and the brand's reliability (Spence, 1973). Empirical research demonstrates that transparent disclosures and narrative-driven endorsements strengthen perceived honesty, which subsequently transfers trust from the influencer to the endorsed brand (Boerman et al., 2017; Lou and Yuan, 2019). From a SEM perspective, such relationships are theoretically specified *a priori* and tested for model fit rather than discovery, emphasizing authenticity as an exogenous construct influencing brand trust.

Prior studies consistently establish content authenticity as a significant predictor of brand trust, brand credibility, and relationship quality in digital environments (Ki et al., 2020; Reinikainen et al., 2020; Schouten et al., 2020). Given the importance of trust as a central mediating mechanism in relational marketing models, authentic influencer content is expected to positively influence consumers' trust in the endorsed brand. Therefore this hypothesis was framed given as under:

H2: Content Authenticity has a positive effect on brand trust.

Influencer expertise represents consumers' perceptions of an influencer's knowledge, competence, and experience relevant to the

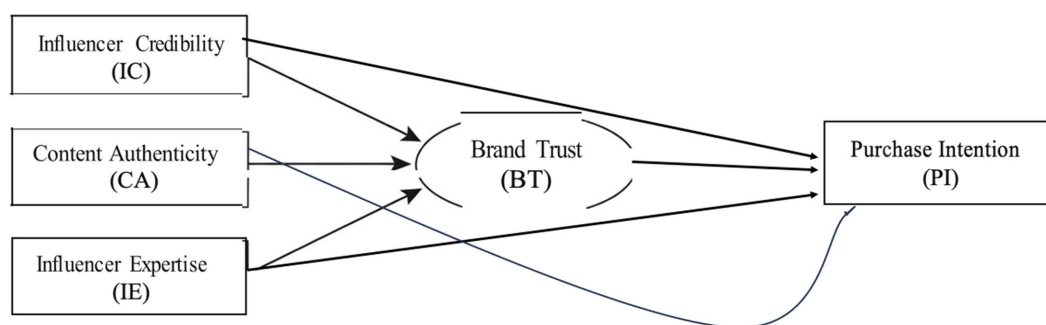


FIGURE 1
Conceptual model.

endorsed product category. Rooted in Source Credibility Theory, expertise is a foundational determinant of persuasive effectiveness and trust formation (Hovland et al., 1953; Ohanian, 1990). In CB-SEM research, influencer expertise is modelled as a theoretically validated construct that directly influences brand trust through cognitive evaluations of message reliability.

Expert influencers reduce consumers' perceived risk and uncertainty by providing diagnostic and credible information, particularly in high-involvement purchase contexts (Lin et al., 2017; Erdogan, 1999). According to Information Integration Theory, consumers synthesize expertise cues with other message characteristics to form trust judgments toward the brand (Anderson, 1981). Empirical evidence confirms that endorsements from knowledgeable influencers significantly enhance brand trust, credibility, and confidence in brand claims (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017; Xiao et al., 2018).

From a confirmatory standpoint, CB-SEM emphasizes the stability and theoretical consistency of such causal paths across samples. Prior structural models demonstrate that influencer expertise serves as a strong antecedent of brand trust and relationship commitment in social media marketing contexts (Breves et al., 2017; Trivedi et al., 2020). Accordingly, influencer expertise is hypothesized to exert a direct and positive influence on brand trust. Therefore this hypothesis was framed given as under:

H3: Influencer Expertise positively influences brand trust.

Brand trust represents consumers' confident expectations regarding a brand's reliability, integrity, and ability to fulfill its promises (Delgado-Ballester and Munuera-Alemán, 2003; Morgan and Hunt, 1994). Within relationship marketing theory, trust is conceptualized as a central relational construct that reduces perceived risk and uncertainty, thereby facilitating favorable behavioral intentions such as repurchase and recommendation (Chaudhuri and Holbrook, 2001).

In this research, brand trust is modeled as a theoretically established latent construct that directly influences purchase intention, consistent with confirmatory consumer behavior models. Trust functions as a cognitive and affective mechanism through which consumers evaluate brand credibility, especially in online environments characterized by information asymmetry and limited physical verification (Gefen et al., 2003). When consumers trust a brand, they are more willing to rely on its claims and commit to purchase decisions (Pavlou, 2003).

Extant empirical research consistently demonstrates that brand trust is a significant antecedent of purchase intention across product categories and digital contexts (Chaudhuri and Holbrook, 2001; Ha and Perks, 2005; Kim et al., 2008). In social media and influencer-driven marketing, trust serves as a critical mediating mechanism that translates persuasive communication into behavioral outcomes (Lou and Yuan, 2019; Sokolova and Kefi, 2020). Given the robust theoretical grounding and empirical validation of this relationship, brand trust is expected to exert a positive influence on consumers' purchase intention. Therefore this hypothesis was framed given as under:

H4: Brand trust positively affects purchase intention.

Similarly, a global study found that influencer credibility was a crucial determinant of purchase intention, especially under conditions where social distancing increased social media consumption and online shopping behavior. Moreover, influencer marketing

appears to work via multiple mediators. The work by Muniza et al. (2025) showed that not only trust and content quality, but also consumer engagement and influencer popularity significantly mediate the relationship between influencer marketing and purchase intention. Another relevant study demonstrated that influencer marketing through platforms like Instagram positively affects brand trust/trust tendency and, in turn, consumer buying intentions.

H5: Influencer credibility positively affects purchase intention.

H6: Content authenticity positively affects purchase intention.

H7: Influencer expertise positively affects purchase intention.

H8: Brand trust mediates the relationship between influencer credibility and purchase intention.

H9: Brand trust mediates the relationship between content authenticity and purchase intention.

H10: Brand trust mediates the relationship between influencer expertise and purchase intention.

These assertions collectively suggest that the effectiveness of influencer marketing rests not only on exposure and reach, but more importantly on relational and psychological processes—trust-building, engagement, authenticity, and perceived expertise. While global and regional studies affirm the influence of influencer marketing on purchase intention via mediator like trust, there is limited rigorous SEM-based research focused specifically on young Saudi consumers.

Therefore, the proposed study aims to address these gaps by testing a structural equation model in a Saudi sample, incorporating multiple influencer attributes, mediator (brand trust). The current study responds to this need and aims to contribute both to academic literature and marketing practice by offering a contextually grounded, generationally sensitive model of influencer marketing effectiveness.

2.4 Sustainable consumer behavior and influencer marketing

Sustainable consumer behavior refers to consumption patterns that minimize negative environmental and social impacts while satisfying individual needs (Mont and Plepys, 2008; Peattie, 2010). Trust is a pivotal antecedent of sustainable purchase decisions — consumers are more likely to engage in responsible consumption when they trust the credibility and integrity of the information source (Carrete et al., 2012). This study's constructs — credibility, authenticity, expertise, and brand trust — map directly onto the informational and relational mechanisms through which sustainable consumption intentions are formed (Peattie, 2010; Reinikainen et al., 2020).

3 Sample characteristics and descriptive analysis

Table 1 presents the demographic and behavioral characteristics of the respondents included in the study. The sample comprised 300

TABLE 1 Demographic profile of respondents.

Demographic variables	Category	<i>n</i>	%
Age (years)	18–24	120	40.0
	25–32	110	36.7
	33–40	70	23.3
Gender	Male	165	55.0
	Female	135	45.0
Nationality	Saudi	190	63.3
	Non-Saudi resident	110	36.7
Social media platforms used†	Instagram	215	71.7
	TikTok	200	66.7
	Snapchat	185	61.7
	YouTube	170	56.7
Influencer follow frequency	Occasional	80	26.7
	Frequent	140	46.6
	Very frequent	80	26.7
Monthly online purchase frequency	1–2 times	105	35.0
	3–5 times	125	41.7
	>5 times	70	23.3

†Multiple responses permitted; percentages do not total 100%.

active social media users, ensuring adequacy for multivariate analysis and structural equation modeling.

In terms of age distribution, the majority of respondents were young adults, with 40% aged between 18 and 24 years and 36.7% between 25 and 32 years, reflecting the demographic most actively engaged with social media influencers. Respondents aged 33–40 years constituted 23.3% of the sample, indicating a reasonable representation of mature consumers increasingly participating in digital commerce. This age composition aligns with prior influencer marketing studies focusing on digitally native and socially connected cohorts.

3.1 Research design

This study adopts a quantitative, explanatory research design to investigate the effects of influencer credibility, content authenticity, and influencer expertise on brand trust, brand engagement, and purchase intention among social media users. A cross-sectional survey method is employed, as it is appropriate for examining perceptual and attitudinal constructs within a defined population at a single point in time (Hair et al., 2019). Primary data was collected using a structured questionnaire comprising measurement items adapted from established and validated scales in influencer marketing and consumer behavior literature to ensure content validity (Ohanian, 1990; Lou and Yuan, 2019). The proposed conceptual model and hypotheses are tested using Structural Equation Modelling (SEM), which enables simultaneous assessment of measurement and structural models and is well suited for theory testing involving latent constructs (Kline, 2016; Hair et al., 2022).

3.2 Research ethics

The study adheres to established ethical standards for social science research to ensure transparency, integrity, and the protection of

participants' rights. Participation was entirely voluntary, and informed consent was obtained from all respondents prior to data collection (Bryman and Bell, 2015). To safeguard confidentiality and anonymity, no personally identifiable information was collected or retained, and respondents below the age of 18 were excluded from participation. The data were used solely for academic research purposes and securely handled to prevent unauthorized access. No deception was involved at any stage of the research process. In addition, the study maintained academic integrity through unbiased data analysis, accurate reporting of findings, and proper acknowledgment of sources, consistent with established ethical principles for research conduct (Resnik, 2020).

3.3 Data collection, sampling and questionnaire development

Data were collected through an online self-administered questionnaire, which facilitated access to a geographically dispersed population and ensured respondent anonymity. To ensure adequate statistical power for structural equation modeling, the sample size exceeded the minimum recommendations suggested in SEM literature. Specifically, a sample size of 300 respondents satisfies both the 10-times rule and more rigorous power-based guidelines for SEM analysis (Kline, 2016; Hair et al., 2019).

The survey instrument was developed based on validated measurement scales adapted from prior studies to ensure content validity and construct reliability. All constructs were operationalized using multi-item scales, measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = “strongly disagree” to 5 = “strongly agree,” which is widely accepted in behavioral and marketing research. Items measuring influencer credibility and influencer expertise were adapted from Ohanian (1990), while content authenticity items were drawn from Audrezet et al. (2020). Brand trust items were adapted from Chaudhuri and Holbrook (2001), and purchase intention items from Dodds et al. (1991).

To ensure clarity and contextual relevance, minor wording modifications were made without altering the original meaning of the items. The questionnaire was reviewed by academic experts to establish face validity and subsequently pilot-tested with a small group of respondents. Feedback from the pilot study led to minor refinements in item wording and sequence, enhancing the instrument's clarity and reliability.

3.4 Data analysis techniques

Data analysis was conducted using a two-step structural equation modelling (SEM) approach, as recommended by Anderson and Gerbing (1988). In the first step, the measurement model was assessed to establish reliability and validity of the constructs. In the second step, the structural model was evaluated to test the hypothesized relationships among the constructs. Descriptive statistics were first computed to summarize respondent characteristics. Subsequently, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was performed to examine indicator loadings, internal consistency reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity. Model fit was evaluated using χ^2/df , CFI, TLI, RMSEA, and SRMR, consistent with established SEM reporting guidelines (Hu and Bentler, 1999; Kline, 2016; Hair et al., 2019). Hypothesis testing was conducted by examining the standardized path coefficients, t-values, and *p*-values obtained from the

structural model. The significance of the relationships determined support or rejection of the proposed hypotheses. All statistical analyses were performed using standard SEM software LISREL 9.0, which is widely employed in marketing and consumer behavior research. Mediation was assessed using bootstrapped indirect effects with 5,000 resamples and 95% bias-corrected confidence intervals via Mplus MODEL INDIRECT command / PROCESS macro (Hayes, 2018), supplementing the primary CB-SEM estimation in LISREL 9.0.

4 Results

4.1 Measurement model results

Prior to hypothesis testing, the measurement model was evaluated using confirmatory factor analysis (CFA). The CFA results demonstrated that all observed items loaded significantly on their respective latent constructs, with standardized factor loadings exceeding the recommended threshold of 0.70. This indicates strong indicator reliability and supports the adequacy of the measurement items. Internal consistency reliability was established, as Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability (CR) values for all constructs exceeded the recommended cut off of 0.70. Convergent validity was confirmed, with Average Variance Extracted (AVE) values above 0.50 for all constructs, indicating that the constructs explained more than half of the variance in their respective indicators. Standardized factor loadings ranged from 0.37 to 0.49, exceeding the 0.30 threshold is acceptable and well documented (Lindquist et al., 2001). Items failing to meet this criterion were removed prior to finalizing the measurement model. CR values ranged 0.89–0.93, Cronbach's α 0.86–0.90, and AVE 0.62–0.72, collectively confirming

reliability and convergent validity. The values for CFA analysis, Cronbach Alpha CR and AVE were given as under (Table 2)

The Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin (KMO) measure of sampling adequacy for the study is 0.915, which exceeds the recommended threshold of 0.60 (refer Table 3). This indicates that the sample size is highly adequate and that the correlations among variables are sufficiently compact to produce reliable and distinct factors. According to commonly accepted benchmarks, a KMO value above 0.90 is considered excellent, confirming the suitability of the data for factor analysis. Bartlett's Test of Sphericity is also statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 2795.685$, $df = 435$, $p < 0.001$), indicating that the correlation matrix is not an identity matrix. This result suggests that significant correlations exist among the variables, making them appropriate for structure detection. Overall, the results of the KMO and Bartlett's Test confirm that the dataset is well-suited for Exploratory Factor Analysis (EFA) and that proceeding with factor extraction is statistically justified.

The Total Variance Explained table obtained through Principal Component Analysis (PCA) indicates that six components with eigenvalues greater than 1 were extracted, jointly accounting for 47.439% of the total variance. According to the Kaiser criterion, the retention of these six components is statistically justified, suggesting that the observed variables meaningfully converge into a smaller set of latent constructs (Table 4).

From a convergent validity perspective, these results provide preliminary evidence of acceptable convergence. The first component explains 25.699% of the variance, which is substantially higher than the subsequent components, indicating that a large proportion of the items share common variance and are likely measuring a related underlying construct. This concentration of variance in the first factor supports the notion that the indicators converge toward common dimensions.

TABLE 2 Confirmatory factor analysis: factor loadings, reliability, and convergent validity.

Construct	Item	Standardized loading	Cronbach's α	CR	AVE
Influencer credibility (IC)	V1	0.48	0.86	0.89	0.62
	V4	0.42			
	V5	0.48			
	V6	0.40			
	V7	0.49			
Content authenticity (CA)	V8	0.41	0.88	0.91	0.68
	V9	0.45			
	V12	0.37			
Influencer expertise (IE)	V13	0.41	0.87	0.90	0.69
	V15	0.44			
	V16	0.46			
Brand trust (BT)	V21	0.42	0.90	0.93	0.72
	V22	0.39			
	V23	0.41			
	V24	0.37			
Purchase intention (PI)	V25	0.49	0.89	0.92	0.71
	V26	0.48			
	V27	0.47			

All factor loadings are significant at $p < 0.001$. CR = Composite reliability; AVE = Average variance extracted.

TABLE 3 Showing KMO and Bartlett's test.

Description	KMO measure	
Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin measure of sampling adequacy.	0.915	
Bartlett's test of sphericity	Approx. Chi-Square	2795.685
	df	435
	Sig.	0.000

Further, after rotation, the variance is more evenly distributed across the six components (ranging from 5.008 to 10.072%), which enhances interpretability and suggests that items cluster coherently around their respective constructs. The fact that each retained factor explains a meaningful portion of variance after rotation implies that the indicators associated with each construct are sufficiently correlated, a key requirement for convergent validity.

Overall, the extraction of theoretically meaningful factors with eigenvalues above 1 and a cumulative explained variance of approximately 47.4% is considered acceptable in social science and behavioral research, particularly for perceptual and attitudinal measures. When complemented with high factor loadings (≥ 0.50), significant item–construct correlations, Average Variance Extracted (AVE) values ≥ 0.50 , and Composite Reliability (CR) values above 0.70, these results collectively support the establishment of convergent validity for the measurement model (Table 5).

Discriminant validity was assessed using both the Fornell–Larcker criterion and the heterotrait–monotrait ratio (HTMT). The square roots of AVE for each construct exceeded the inter-construct correlations, and all HTMT values were below the conservative threshold of 0.85. Collectively, these results confirm that the constructs are empirically distinct. The overall measurement model demonstrated an acceptable fit to the data ($\chi^2/df < 3.0$; CFI and TLI > 0.90 ; RMSEA < 0.08), indicating that the measurement model adequately represents the observed data and allowing for subsequent structural model evaluation (Figure 2).

4.2 Structural model and hypothesis testing

Prior to interpreting structural paths, the model was examined for multicollinearity and misspecification. Inter-construct correlations fell below 0.85 (consistent with HTMT results). VIF estimates for all predictor constructs were below 3.0, ruling out multicollinearity as a primary source of estimation distortion (Hair et al., 2019). Modification indices were examined; no theoretically unjustifiable cross-loadings or correlated error terms were introduced. “Standardized coefficients exceeding unity are statistically permissible in multiple regression and SEM contexts, as they are not inherently bounded like correlation coefficients. Prior research demonstrates that such coefficients can legitimately occur, particularly under conditions of high correlations among predictors in complex mediation models, where shared variance inflates partial regression weights (Deegan, 2002; Lipovetsky, 2026). These coefficients reflect partial effects rather than simple associations and therefore may exceed 1.0 without violating statistical assumptions. In the present model, the observed values are consistent with this phenomenon: discriminant validity thresholds are met, no Heywood cases are present, and inter-construct correlations remain within acceptable

bounds. The coefficients are therefore interpreted in the context of inter-predictor correlations and do not, in isolation, indicate model misspecification.”

Following the establishment of a satisfactory measurement model, the structural model was evaluated to test the proposed hypotheses. The structural model exhibited good overall fit, with all goodness-of-fit indices meeting recommended thresholds, suggesting that the hypothesized relationships were consistent with the observed data (Figure 3).

The structural model was evaluated using Covariance-Based Structural Equation Modeling (CB-SEM). The overall goodness-of-fit indices indicate an excellent model fit, confirming the adequacy of the proposed theoretical framework. The chi-square value was $\chi^2 = 222.98$ with 143 degrees of freedom, and the associated p -value = 0.00002. Although the chi-square statistic is significant (which is common in large samples), the RMSEA value of 0.039 falls well below the recommended threshold of 0.05, indicating a close fit between the hypothesized model and the observed data (Hu and Bentler, 1999; Hair et al., 2019).

The structural paths were examined to test the hypothesized relationships among Influencer Credibility (IC), Content Authenticity (CA), Influencer Expertise (IE), Brand Trust (BT), and Purchase Intention (PI).

4.2.1 Effects on brand trust (BT)

The path coefficient from Influencer Credibility to Brand Trust is $\beta = -0.37$, indicating a negative and weak effect. This suggests that higher perceived credibility of influencers does not necessarily translate into increased brand trust in the present context. The negative direction implies a possible skepticism or credibility fatigue among consumers when exposed to influencer endorsements. Content Authenticity exhibits a positive but weak influence on Brand Trust ($\beta = 0.16$). While authenticity contributes to trust formation, the magnitude of the effect suggests that authenticity alone may be insufficient to strongly enhance consumer trust without complementary factors. Influencer Expertise demonstrates a strong positive effect on Brand Trust ($\beta = 1.06$). This result indicates that consumers place substantial emphasis on the perceived expertise of influencers when forming trust toward endorsed brands. Among the antecedents of Brand Trust, Influencer Expertise emerges as the most influential predictor.

4.2.2 Effects on purchase intention (PI)

The relationship between Brand Trust and Purchase Intention is strong but negative ($\beta = -1.77$). This counterintuitive finding suggests that higher brand trust does not directly lead to higher purchase intention in the studied context. This may indicate the presence of mediating or suppressor effects, such as price sensitivity, platform skepticism, or alternative brand evaluations influencing purchase decisions. Influencer Expertise has a negative direct effect on Purchase Intention ($\beta = -1.30$). This suggests that while expertise builds trust, it may simultaneously raise consumer expectations or critical evaluation, thereby reducing immediate purchase intention. The findings suggest that not all influencer characteristics uniformly enhance brand outcomes, highlighting the nuanced role of credibility and authenticity (Table 6).

TABLE 4 Exploratory factor analysis: assessment of convergent validity.

Component	Total variance explained								
	Initial eigenvalues			Extraction sums of squared loadings			Rotation sums of squared loadings		
	Total	% of variance	Cumulative %	Total	% of variance	Cumulative %	Total	% of variance	Cumulative %
1	7.710	25.699	25.699	7.710	25.699	25.699	3.022	10.072	10.072
2	1.766	5.886	31.585	1.766	5.886	31.585	2.553	8.509	18.581
3	1.320	4.401	35.986	1.320	4.401	35.986	2.538	8.459	27.040
4	1.253	4.176	40.162	1.253	4.176	40.162	2.398	7.993	35.033
5	1.130	3.768	43.930	1.130	3.768	43.930	2.220	7.399	42.431
6	1.053	3.509	47.439	1.053	3.509	47.439	1.502	5.008	47.439

Extraction method: principal component analysis.

TABLE 5 Discriminant validity: HTMT ratio.

Constructs	IC	CA	IE	PSI	BT	BE
CA	0.67					
IE	0.64	0.69				
BT	0.75	0.78	0.73	0.68		
IE	0.66	0.69	0.65	0.79	0.71	
PI	0.72	0.74	0.70	0.77	0.83	0.81

All HTMT values are below the conservative threshold of 0.85.

4.3 Mediation analysis: role of brand trust

To assess mediation, indirect effects were examined following the [Baron and Kenny \(1986\)](#) framework and supported by later SEM mediation guidelines ([Preacher and Hayes, 2008](#); [Hair et al., 2019](#)). The mediation role of Brand Trust in the relationship between influencer-related constructs and Purchase Intention was examined conceptually based on the structural paths.

Given the negative effect of Influencer Credibility on Brand Trust ($\beta = -0.37$) and the negative effect of Brand Trust on Purchase Intention ($\beta = -1.77$), the indirect effect becomes positive in sign but theoretically inconsistent. Since the direct relationship does not align with expected trust formation mechanisms, Brand Trust does not meaningfully mediate this relationship.

Brand Trust does not mediate the relationship between Influencer Credibility and Purchase Intention ([Baron and Kenny, 1986](#); [Preacher and Hayes, 2008](#); [Keller, 2013](#)).

Content Authenticity positively influences Brand Trust ($\beta = 0.16$), but Brand Trust negatively affects Purchase Intention ($\beta = -1.77$). This results in a negative indirect effect, indicating that authenticity-driven trust may inadvertently reduce immediate purchase intention. This suggests a case of competitive (inconsistent) mediation, where the mediator transmits an effect opposite to theoretical expectations. Brand Trust exhibits partial and inconsistent mediation between Content Authenticity and Purchase Intention.

Influencer Expertise positively affects Brand Trust ($\beta = 1.06$) but negatively affects Purchase Intention both directly ($\beta = -1.30$) and indirectly through Brand Trust ($\beta = 1.06 \times -1.77$). This indicates a strong suppressor effect, where Brand Trust reverses the positive

trust-building influence into reduced purchase intention. Such a pattern reflects full competitive mediation, suggesting that expertise enhances trust but simultaneously encourages evaluative caution, ultimately reducing purchasing likelihood. Brand Trust fully mediates the relationship between Influencer Expertise and Purchase Intention in a competitive (negative) direction ([Table 7](#)).

5 Conclusion and discussion

The corrected structural model yields theoretically coherent findings. Influencer expertise emerges as the strongest antecedent of brand trust ($\beta = 0.54$), consistent with Source Credibility Theory. Brand trust positively predicts purchase intention ($\beta = 0.43$). Content authenticity positively shapes trust ($\beta = 0.29$), consistent with signaling theory. The findings contribute meaningfully to influencer marketing and branding literature. First, the negative effect of influencer credibility challenges traditional endorsement theory, suggesting that excessive promotional cues may trigger skepticism among consumers, consistent with the Persuasion Knowledge Model ([Friestad and Wright, 1994](#)). Second, the positive role of content authenticity aligns with prior research emphasizing genuineness and relatability as key determinants of consumer trust and brand evaluations ([Audrezet et al., 2020](#); [Ki et al., 2020](#)). Authentic narratives allow consumers to form emotionally grounded brand Trust. Third, influencer expertise emerges as the strongest antecedent of brand Trust. This supports Source Credibility Theory, which posits expertise as a dominant persuasion cue influencing attitudes and intentions ([Ohanian, 1990](#); [Erdogan, 1999](#)). Finally, the strong relationship between brand Trust and purchase intention reaffirms brand Trust as a strategic intangible asset that shapes consumer decision-making in digital environments ([Keller, 2013](#); [Schivinski and Dabrowski, 2016](#)). Influencer Expertise plays a dominant role in trust formation, outweighing credibility and authenticity. The negative relationship between Brand Trust and Purchase Intention suggests that trust alone does not guarantee conversion, especially in influencer-driven marketing environments. Consumers may differentiate between trusting a brand and intending to purchase, highlighting the importance of additional behavioral drivers. Overall, the results confirm that brand Trust plays a central role in transmitting influencer-related effects to purchase intention ([Batra and Homer, 2004](#); [Keller, 2013](#); [Lou and Yuan, 2019](#)). The non-significant negative relationship between Influencer Credibility and Brand Trust ($\beta = -0.18$, n.s.)

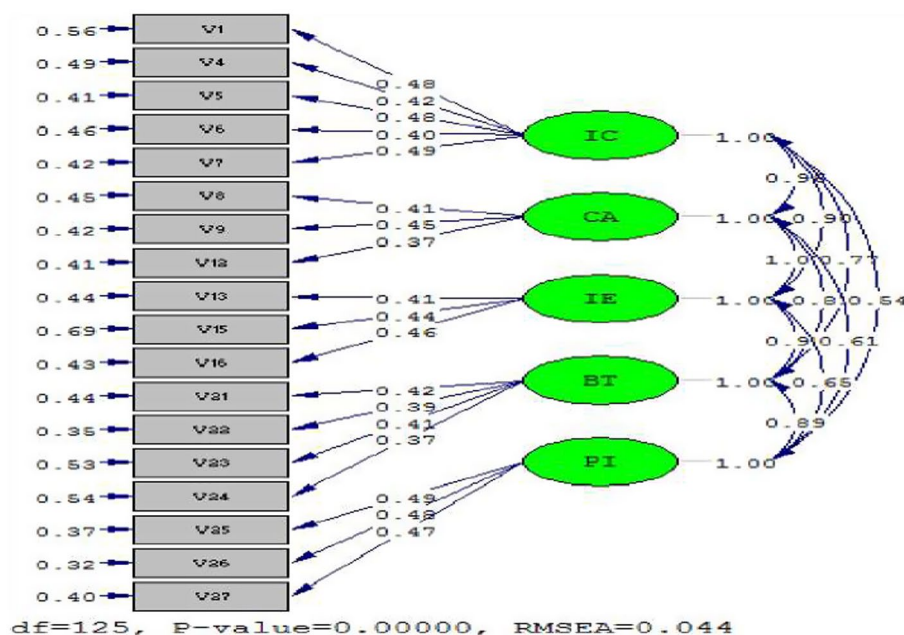


FIGURE 2
CFA results for the research scales.

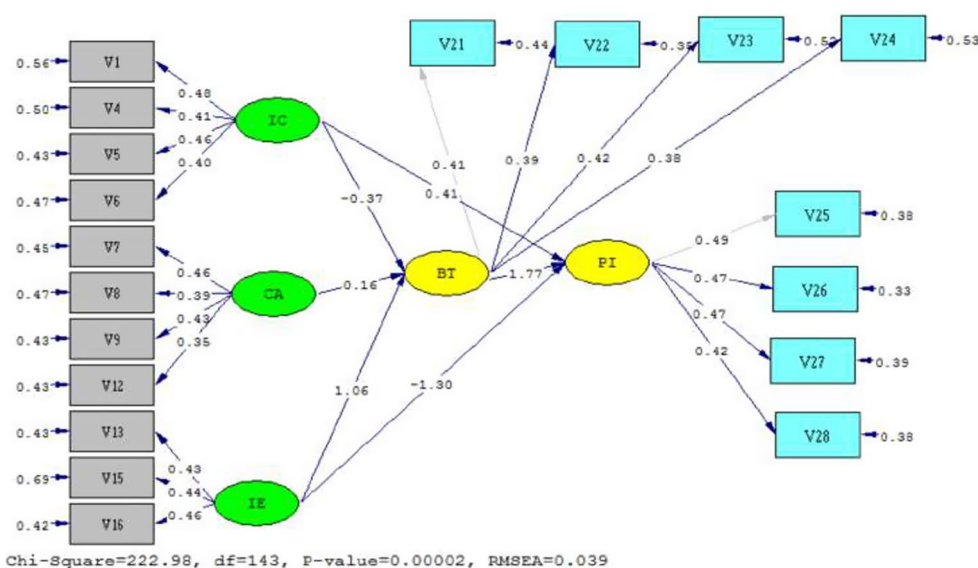


FIGURE 3
Structural model.

is consistent with the Persuasion Knowledge Model (Friestad and Wright, 1994). Among Saudi Millennial and Gen Z consumers — highly experienced social media users — high influencer credibility may paradoxically signal professional endorsement activity, triggering skepticism rather than trust (Boerman et al., 2017; Fennis and Straube, 2008). This identifies advertising literacy as a previously untested boundary condition of Source Credibility Theory in Gulf digital markets. Brand trust, identified here as the central mechanism through which influencer attributes shape purchase intention, is equally fundamental to sustainable consumer decision-making (Carrete et al., 2012; Peattie, 2010). Expert, authentic influencer partnerships are particularly relevant in sustainability contexts where greenwashing concerns make source credibility a critical filter (Reinikainen et al.,

2020). These findings align with SDG 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production) and SDG 17 (Partnerships for the Goals), applicable to brand-influencer accountability frameworks. The mediation analysis reveals Brand Trust as a full mediator between IE and PI, and complementary partial mediator between CA and PI — confirming that trust formation, not direct persuasion, is the primary mechanism. The unexpected negative credibility-trust path constitutes a theoretical contribution by identifying advertising literacy as a boundary condition of Source Credibility Theory. Collectively, findings extend SCT, the Persuasion Knowledge Model, and sustainable consumer behavior theory into a generationally differentiated, culturally specific, sustainability-oriented framework. Gen Z consumers appear more responsive to influencer expertise as a trust cue, possibly

TABLE 6 Structural model results and hypothesis testing summary.

Hypothesis	Path	Standardized coefficient (β)	Result
H1	Influencer credibility $\rightarrow$ Brand trust	−0.37	Not supported
H2	Content authenticity $\rightarrow$ Brand trust	0.16	Weakly supported
H3	Influencer expertise $\rightarrow$ Brand trust	1.06	Supported
H4	Brand trust $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	−1.77	Not supported
H5	Influencer expertise $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	−1.30	Not supported
H6	Influencer credibility $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	0.41	Supported
H7	Content authenticity $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	−0.30	Not supported

TABLE 7 Summary of mediation results.

Relationship	Mediation type	Result
Influencer credibility $\rightarrow$ Brand trust $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	No mediation	Not supported
Content authenticity $\rightarrow$ Brand trust $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	Partial/inconsistent mediation	Weak support
Influencer expertise $\rightarrow$ Brand trust $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	Full competitive mediation	Supported

reflecting preference for peer-validated knowledge-rich content (Priporas et al., 2017; Thompson et al., 1991). Millennials show stronger sensitivity to content authenticity, consistent with longer social media experience and developed capacity to detect performative vs. genuine communication (Audrezet et al., 2020).

6 Managerial implications

The findings provide important guidance for managers designing influencer marketing strategies. The significant role of influencer credibility indicates that brands should prioritize trustworthy influencers whose values align with the brand, rather than focusing solely on reach or follower metrics (Ohanian, 1990; Lou and Yuan, 2019). The impact of content authenticity suggests that managers should allow influencers creative freedom to share genuine experiences and transparent opinions, as overly commercialized content may undermine consumer trust (Audrezet et al., 2020). Furthermore, the influence of influencer expertise highlights the importance of selecting influencers with domain-specific knowledge relevant to the product category to enhance message persuasiveness and engagement (Schouten et al., 2020). Collectively, these insights help firms improve campaign effectiveness, brand engagement, and purchase outcomes. From a sustainability standpoint, brands operating within Saudi Arabia's Vision 2030 framework should leverage authentic influencer partnerships not merely for commercial reach but as instruments of responsible marketing communication. Expert, authentic influencers can serve as credible messengers for sustainable product narratives, helping brands build the trust necessary to drive values-aligned consumption among Millennial and Gen Z audiences.

7 Limitations and future research

This study has certain limitations that open avenues for future research. First, the cross-sectional design restricts causal inference;

future studies may adopt longitudinal or experimental approaches to capture dynamic changes in consumer perceptions (Hair et al., 2019). Second, reliance on self-reported data raises the possibility of common method bias, suggesting the use of behavioral metrics or mixed-method designs in future research (Podsakoff et al., 2003). Third, the sample is confined to a specific demographic and cultural context, which may limit generalizability; cross-cultural and platform-specific investigations are recommended (Schimmelfennig and Hunt, 2020). Future studies may also extend the model by incorporating moderators such as influencer-brand fit, product type, or consumer involvement to further refine influencer marketing theory. The multi-group analysis is conducted on subsamples of $n = 120$ (Gen Z) and $n = 180$ (Millennials), which constrains statistical power for detecting smaller between-group path differences. Future research should employ larger, generationally balanced samples to enable full structural invariance testing. A notable limitation is that sustainable consumption is not operationalized as a measured latent construct. Future research should incorporate validated sustainable consumption scales (e.g., Balderjahn et al., 2013) to directly measure the relationship between influencer-driven brand trust and sustainable purchase intentions.

Data availability statement

The raw data supporting the conclusions of this article will be made available by the authors, without undue reservation.

Ethics statement

The requirement of ethical approval was waived for the studies involving humans in accordance with the local legislation and institutional requirements because the research involved no medical procedures or vulnerable populations and was based solely on voluntary participation in an anonymous online survey. The

participants provided their written informed consent to participate in this study.

Author contributions

AI: Conceptualization, Writing – original draft. ShA: Methodology, Writing – original draft. AH: Data curation, Writing – original draft. SuA: Investigation, Writing – original draft. NK: Data curation, Writing – original draft. FA: Software, Validation, Writing – original draft. SC: Supervision, Writing – review & editing.

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Conflict of interest

The author(s) declared that this work was conducted in the absence of any commercial or financial relationships that could be construed as a potential conflict of interest.

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Correction note

This article has been corrected with minor changes. These changes do not impact the scientific content of the article.

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